

PEDESTRIAN SAFETY

‘Stars On Cars’ Rating System Will Finally Grade How Safe Vehicles Are For People Their Drivers Hit

The National Highway Traffic Safety Administration has finally changed the nation's consumer safety rating system for new automobiles to accommodate vulnerable road users.

**By Gersh Kuntzman**

3:00 PM EST on November 19, 2024



Photo: Brad Greenlee

How about a tip of the hat for the new NCAP?

Activists are lauding the National Highway Traffic Safety Administration for finally moving forward on congressionally-mandated changes to the nation's new ca

rating system so that the crucial safety grade reflects dangers to people *outside* the cars — not just their occupants.

Going forward, the New Car Assessment Program (NCAP) will offer higher scores to cars equipped with blind spot warning, blind spot intervention, lane keeping assist, and pedestrian automatic emergency braking. Cars without those technologies can still be produced and sold, but might not qualify for a coveted five-star safety rating.

Additionally, the finalized NCAP will:

- strengthen existing testing procedures and performance criteria for driver assistance technologies that are already included in NCAP, such as automatic emergency braking, which differs from its pedestrian version.
- add a “roadmap” to accommodate future updates amid ongoing research and technological advancements in vehicle safety, including crash avoidance and crashworthiness improvements “to protect bicyclists and motorcyclists and an updated rating system.”
- add a “crashworthiness pedestrian protection program” to “evaluate whether a vehicle’s front end will mitigate injuries and fatalities in vehicle-to-pedestrian impacts.”

That last one has been a longstanding demand of advocates as sedans and SUVs have gotten bulkier and boxier. Such a design tends to throw victims under the vehicle, where their injuries are often compounded, rather than pushing them up and over the hood of the car.

“The adopted pedestrian protection testing will evaluate the potential risk of head, upper leg, lower leg, and knee injuries to pedestrians hit by the front of vehicles,” NHTSA said in the announced rule change. “The agency expects that vehicles that score well in these tests will do so by using designs that absorb energy, reduce hard points of contact, and include a front-end profile that will cause less injury to a pedestrian in a crash.”

Advocates hailed the improvement, which was announced late on Monday, because it will finally provide car buyers with information about whether the

vehicle is safe for its possible victims.

“This action by NHTSA is long overdue and will save lives,” said Amy Cohen, who co-founded the national group Families for Safe Streets after her 12-year-old son, Sammy, was killed by a driver in New York City in 2014. “Consumers deserve access to a complete picture of the safety risks involved with different vehicle types.”

The change in the NCAP comes after years of advocacy. Three years ago, [a Families for Safe Streets petition](#) — headlined, “dangerous cars are killing our children” — generated more than 45,000 signatures. The petition was created by Jessica Riester Hart, whose 5-year-old daughter, Allison, was killed by the driver of a large vehicle in a crosswalk in 2021.

“It is outrageous that our vehicle safety rating system only applies to the safety of those inside the vehicle, and does not take into account those outside,” Hart said at the time, citing statistics that vehicles are on average 24 percent bigger than they were in 2000. “It is no surprise that they are also disproportionately deadly for pedestrians, cyclists, and those driving smaller vehicles.”

The move comes also as pedestrian deaths have risen more than 50 percent over the last decade, to roughly 7,300 per year, partly due to the increasingly blocky front ends of today’s cars, [as Streetsblog has repeatedly reported](#). The average U.S. vehicle has gotten [eight inches taller](#) over the past three decades, which experts say has helped accelerate a pedestrian death crisis that claimed 7,400 lives on U.S. roads in 2021 alone, and another 777 people in off-road spaces that same year.

Recommended



OPINION: Make Cars Safer for People Outside of Vehicles

Eve Kessler

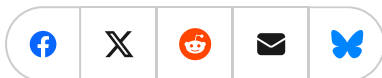
June 2, 2022



Transportation Secretary Pete Buttigieg celebrated his agency's work as getting closer to the "long-term goal of zero road fatalities."

"Like our move earlier this year to make automatic emergency braking standard on new passenger cars and light trucks, these changes to the 5-Star Safety Ratings will speed up adoption of technologies that reduce the frequency and severity of crashes while helping consumers make informed decisions about buying a new car," Buttigieg added.

The changes announced this week take effect with the 2026 model year.



Gersh Kuntzman

Tabloid legend Gersh Kuntzman has been with New York newspapers since 1989, including stints at the New York Daily News, the Post, the Brooklyn Paper and even a cup of coffee with the Times. He's also the writer and producer of "Murder at the Food Coop," which was a hit at the NYC Fringe Festival in 2016, and "SUV: The Musical" in 2007. He also writes the Cycle of Rage column, which is archived [here](#).

Read More: [CAR CRASHES](#) | [CRASH REPORTS](#) | [CRASHES](#) | [GOVERNMENT ORGANIZATIONS](#) | [NCAP](#) | [NHTSA](#) | [PEDESTRIAN SAFETY](#)



Stay in touch

Sign up for our free newsletter

SIGN UP

Streetsblog has migrated to a new comment system. New commenters can register directly in the comments section of any article. Returning commenters: your previous comments and display name have been preserved, but you'll need to reclaim your account by clicking "Forgot your password?" on the sign-in form, entering your email, and following the verification link to set a new password — this is required because passwords could not be carried over during the migration. For questions, contact tips@streetsblog.org.

More from Streetsblog USA

AI

Where the Battles Against Harmful Highways and Hyper-Scale Data Centers Collide



Kea Wilson September 22, 2026

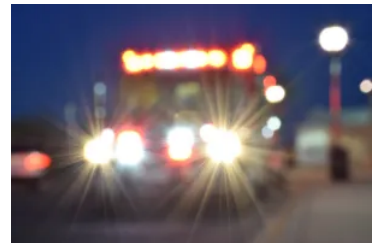


CAR CRASHES

I Survived the Santa Monica Farmer's Market Crash



Melissa H. Cronin September 22, 2026



TODAY'S HEADLINES

Tuesday's Headlines Are a Speed Trap



Blake Aued September 22, 2026



What Would It Take to Get ‘Fast, Free Buses’ Nationwide?



Kea Wilson September 21, 2026

The Five Questions Every Community Should Ask Itself Before It Debuts a New Bike Path



Seth Lieber September 21, 2026

[See all posts](#) →

Covering the movement to end car dependency and improve biking, walking and transit in America.

Sign up for our free newsletter

Email

SIGN UP



Basics

About Us

Staff & Board

Donate to Streetsblog

Write For Streetsblog USA or

Submit a Tip

Job Listings



Contact Us

List an event on Streetsblog

USA

NYC EMPIRE STATE MASS LA SF CAL CHI DONATE

© Copyright 2026

